to Jaunpur, Akbar was very annoyed when a precious elephant drowned at Chausa and severely punished the officer in charge, Sadiq Khan. Sadiq Khan's jagir was confiscated, he was excluded from attendance at court, and was told to find another good elephant to replace the lost one. Sadiq Khan responded with panache to the order, returning in two years' time with 100 elephants and was immediately restored to favour.*

Akbar then returned to Jaunpur where he met with the harem and his sons and spent a pleasant month of ease and rest. Akbar, like all the Mughal emperors before and after him, took his harem with him everywhere he went, on military campaigns, and on hunts and other excursions. The presence of these women was often crucial in maintaining his political networks through the information they collected from their politically powerful relatives and agents. The harem was also a place of refuge and safety for the Padshah. When he was ill, or wounded, it was the women who tended to him, their lives intricately tied up in his safety and well-being. In the month that they spent in Jaunpur, there would have been a great deal for them to see and do, for Jaunpur was a thriving city and though no longer a capital city of the sultanate, a local trader listed it as having fifty-two bazaars, fifty-two wholesale markets, and fifty-two caravanserais as testimony to its vibrancy and size.

As the Padshah and his retinue were making their leisurely way back to the capital, Akbar called for Badauni at Kannauj and gave him a book called the *Singhasan Battisi* (32 Tales of the Throne) a collection of moral tales about the legendary Vikramaditya, King of Malwa. 'I received his Majesty's instructions,' wrote Badauni, 'to make a translation of it in prose and verse. I was to begin the work at once, and present a leaf of my work on that very day.' Akbar appointed a Brahmin to translate and interpret the Sanskrit verses for Badauni, who set to work immediately and read out the first section in Persian that very evening. The completed book was called *Namah-i Khirad-Afza* and it became part of the imperial library. Akbar had gauged in Badauni the talent to be an excellent translator, a much more talented scholar than he ever was a warrior.

Akbar went on to Delhi, to offer thanks at the Sufi shrines there. He now received the glorious news of Munim Khan having chased Daud Khan all the way to the Afghan capital of Tanda, which was relinquished without a struggle, and Bengal was won. The Mughal party then headed towards Ajmer where, some 20 kilometres outside the city, Akbar dismounted and